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Dick Griffin

Dick Griffin is well known for his innovative trombone style and his collaboration with Rahsaan Roland Kirk. His talents have allowed him to participate in a wide variety of musical and artistic settings.

Dick was interviewed via Zoom on February 12, 2024 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have Dick Griffin with me this morning, not exactly jazz musicians' hours, but I'm going to introduce you as a trombonist, a composer, and a visual artist, and a very creative person from what I've listened to and seen and read. So thanks for joining me.

DG: Thank you for inviting me, and it's always a pleasure, and believe it or not I'm an early riser. I get up sometimes at 5, 6 and 7 o'clock in the morning. And also I do late nights. So I can stay up 'til 3 and 4 and 5, whatever, at night, for playing in the nightclubs. So I don't sleep a lot. I sleep three hours and that's about it. But I can do it two or three times a day.

MR: Would you say your mind is almost always occupied with creating something, whether it's thinking about music or thinking about a blank canvas. Are you preoccupied with that kind of forward thinking?

DG: I am. And you hit on an area that most people don't even ask me — I'm like that even when I'm sitting, if I don't — you know people — just relaxing — I'm either playing chess on my phone or some kind of puzzle or something. My mind is always going, you know like thinking of something creative. And that's how I discovered the multiphonics in the stuff that I play. Because I always look at something and say there's a different way of doing it. And I haven't been as courageous as I lately have about trying the different ways of doing it. Because I was telling my son, we talked — see every coin has two sides, a head and a tail. Every situation that you deal with has a left and a right, a hot and a cold, good and a bad you know. And it's just — so some people look, they stay under only just the hot side and never experience the cold side you know. Or some people stay on the left and never look or deal with the right, or the opposite. So I lately have been just doing different things, even like getting up on different sides of the bed. You know normally I would sleep on a certain side, let me try the other side. And I did it and sometimes, wow, I could have been doing this 40 years ago, you know this is the better side for me. So all of that just lately I've been doing it. And especially in my playing. You know I was breathing a certain way, I was taught to breathe that way and that's the way I breathe. You know like you were taught to ride a bike a certain way and that's the

way you ride it, right? But lately I started to change the method that I breathe. And we would call it diaphragmatic breathing and they call it clavicle or chest breathing. So I never used the chest breathing much you know, and then I said let me try the chest breathing, and it works better for me. Because the muscles, I mean the air is here, in the lungs. One here and one there. So if I push pressure from the chest rather than from the bottom part of my lungs, the top part of my lungs, things come out better. And it's just a simple little thing like that, all these years.

MR: You make me think of a quote I had set aside here from — I had a session with Charles Tolliver and he kept using the word "exploratory." And so I finally asked him, well what does that mean? And he said, "Not playing what you practiced that you know is absolutely perfect for the chord changes."

DG: Um hum.

MR: Yeah. And what you're describing, being creative and exploratory and looking for new ways, does that tend to sometimes result in something that could be considered unintentional or even called a mistake? And how do you deal with it?

DG: Yeah. Well I can go through some of the things I know some of the masters have said and I started to listen to what they have said. There's a John Coltrane — a guy said he'd read a book on John Coltrane and John Coltrane, out of reading the book the only thing that he got from the book it said John Coltrane said, he said practice stuff you don't know. Work on — and then there was a great, great artist friend of mine who probably had the most influential spot in my life was named Ed Clark. Ed Clark was my mentor, my teacher, my best friend, and he just blessed me with so much knowledge and stuff. But he said work on your weakness. Most people fear a runaway or cover-up or figure out ways to not deal with their weakness. And their ego gets into play and you would not let a person know your weakness because you hide them and most of the guys that come across like bullies, they are the weakest person because they are guarding or protecting or sheltering their weakness. So they're the most probably the most cowardice person in the room comes across as a bully, as the most strongest person. "I can beat you up and I can knock you up." They are the most afraid and cowardice person. And I experienced that once because my father, my stepfather, he passed away when I was seven years old. And I have a cousin who used to come and he would bully me and he'd take my marbles and you know everything. And one day my dad said, "If you don't whip his behind I'm going to whip yours." And so we wrestled, we rustled, we tussled, and somehow he was on top of me and I got the thumb of his finger in my mouth and I nearly bit it off. He didn't stop crying and running home 'til he got halfway up the block. From that day on he never, never bullied me or never said anything, and he never, you know made those gestures. That was it.

MR: Did that follow you through your life perhaps with your interpersonal connections with musicians or record labels, club owners?

DG: Yeah, yeah. It did. And then it had, there's periods where I just had to decide and then I wasn't using it. Then lately, just maybe a year or a few months, I got back to it. Because I just turned 84 on January 28. Then I said, you know ain't nothing, I'm not afraid of anything now. I'm not even afraid of death. Because death is inevitable. It's going to happen. So I say why don't you face your fears. There's a saying that says the three F's. Find it, face it, and fix it. And the thing that keeps you from finding it and facing it and fixing it is fear. That's the fourth F. So I say now most of the time we find the problem, we even face it but we don't fix it because we fear the results. So I am less fearful, you know, of anything than I have been all my life, and just turned 84. So it's just, and then I wake up and I like am more excited. I pick up the horn and I play it differently. I just — this whole thing about the head and the tails of any coin — and that's the way life is. Everything you have, everything you have is good. There's a bad waiting on the other side. A balance. And you know you've got to figure out where you're going to be on a particular side of anything. Are you going to be on the left side or the right side? Good side or the bad side? The light side or the dark side? The happy side or the sad side. And you make those choices every day.

MR: I can tell I'm going to feel better after talking to you today.

DG: Oh thank you. Because you make those choices. You know like a lot of times you wake up, you're feeling bad and everything, but are you going to let that bad feeling prevail throughout your day? No. You go to the good feeling.

MR: Can I ask you about when you were oh I'll just pick the age 12 or so, where was the music coming from that you were exposed to and what kind of music was it?

DG: Very good question. I had started taking piano lessons when I was 11 years old. And the reason I started to take piano lessons, I loved music and I would hear music and on the — we called it record player or phonograph where you wind it up and didn't have any electricity or anything, and you put those 78 records on and oh I'd listen to those all day and I was very careful not to break one because if you broke one you got your butt whooped because that was not — you know when you break one it's no repair for those 78s. So all of that, I was listening to music, and in my neighborhood there was a guy named Mr. Jesse, who lived under the hill, and Mr. Jesse worked — he dug ditches. And people don't even know about what ditches is. A young bass player asked me, "What do you mean by ditches?" Ditches are trenches on the side of the road. If you have a gravel road in the south, and most people didn't have paved roads that was different. They had gravel on the roads and when it rained they would get muddy and everything. But Mr. Jesse would dig ditches for a living so he came home full of mud. And he would get out

of his overalls, all muddy and everything, and get his guitar and start to sing and play the blues. And that was — oh we did it every day, a concert every day except the weekends. Because Saturday and Sunday was, you know, Saturday was the shopping day and everything, and Sunday was the going to church day. That was all laid out in our neighborhood. That's what people did. But Monday through Friday Mr. Jesse played the guitar for us you know. And we were kids and we lived on the hill where the water would rise every spring and all of our houses were built up on high steps, I would say at least four feet off the ground. So as kids we could run and play under the house when it would rain. And we had our own little playground under the house on a rainy day. And, but when the water would rise up in the spring there would be all these planks, two by fours and all these different things. These are runways all the way to the street that came up where the water didn't, you know, come, and we could walk straight up into the city. But most of the — the elderly people were careful because they only had just a rope to hold on to and they'd walk on it. So we would get a nickel for running to the grocery store for people, so oh we had a lot of fun. We could run on those things and nobody hardly ever fell in the water and if we did we'd jump out of the water and get back out as kids, making that nickel.

MR: What would you buy with that nickel?

DG: Oh we could buy so many things. We could buy pickles. We could have a sandwich sometimes, or we loved candy so penny and nickel candy, about three or four pieces or seven pieces of candy and all that kind of stuff like that. And I think during that time maybe a soda was a nickel, they would call them — yeah it was about a nickel for a soda. And just a lot — oh if we got 15 cents we could get maybe a sandwich and a soda and then I loved pig ears and I loved all these hogmaws they call them, and all these different sandwiches hogmaw and cheese they called it. I would get the sandwich and sardines, cans of sardines and crackers and all that stuff. That stuff was our meals. We just — and the RC Colas and Barq's Root Beers and all of those things was — Coca Cola was still around, that was probably — and they said at the time Coca Cola had cocaine in it you know.

MR: What was the state of segregation in your neighborhood when you were the age that you're talking about?

DG: Oh ten or twelve — segregation was very prominent. When I say very prominent, we didn't see like white people in our neighborhood hardly. None at night. Maybe during the day you might see one or two insurance salesmen or something, but the whole neighborhood was full of black people. And I could go weeks and days without seeing anybody black — I mean white. And, but going to school during the school time we had to pass through a white neighborhood and we never passed through that white

neighborhood solo, alone. Because we would be maybe somebody'd come out and threaten us or run — you know little kids — run at us or something like that. But this guy named Herbert Delaney, he is deceased now, my best friend, my mentor, he was taking piano lessons. He had a piano and his family was — you know he had a mother and a father and his sister went to Alcorn College and everything, but I looked up to him. He was about four years older than me. My stepfather got killed when I was seven years old, and that was the one that told me if I didn't beat this bully then he was going to beat me and after that I nearly bit the bully's finger off and he never bothered me again. In fact he acted like he was afraid of me rather than me being afraid of him. He never took any of my marbles, never did anything after I did that. But all that said, around twelve years old I was going to elementary school, I would have to go with Herbert Delaney because he was a bigger guy than me and I looked up to him. And in fact from seven years old through my college and everything he was my mentor. He was my good friend, my mentor, I looked up to him and I took advice from him. He actually, you know, gave me some very precious information about my life and my decisions on life and everything. So, but he had a piano in his house. So the piano lessons started because I had to walk home with Herbert Delaney and he would take his piano lesson, the first lesson he took I think they were 25 cents a lesson or some very — I'd save my money up and I said I'm going to take piano lessons. And then the lady, her name was Miss Bessie Marino, and after a year of taking lessons with her she passed away. She got ill and she died. But I never stopped playing the piano. I was in love with music much earlier than that. In fact you asked me a question about when I really recognized my interest in music. My mother used to sing [sings] Glory hallelujah in a spiritual way. And I would get up in my mother's lap and tell her to sing Glory and that was my lullaby to go to sleep every night until I did it so long to my mother said, "You're getting too big for this, you've just got to go to sleep." And I really said, "Mama, sing 'Glory' you know, and she would rock in the rocking chair and sing [sings] Glory, glory hallelujah/ Glory, glory hallelujah. And I would go to sleep.

MR: Those things just stay in your consciousness, don't they?

DG: Oh yeah. They are the roots. You know every tree has a root, right? They're the roots. They're the branches. Those are the roots of your branch of your life. Those are things that people don't see or don't know. Those are things that focus your soul. And all of these things is what you branch out and you grow into a tree and what-have-you, and bear fruit and what-have-you. But the roots are of those things that my mother planted in me. And I have to go through this real briefly. My mother brought me up in the church. That was the first music I heard, the gospel church, the music. And I loved going to church and any — all of my — when I was, before school, all of my plays I learned, Easter plays and

Christmas plays, and I was just in love with music from that state. Then on the other side in my neighborhood B.B. King, Howlin' Wolf, Muddy Waters, Bo Diddley, you name it, there was a cafe in my neighborhood under the hill that these guys used to come weekly. Every week it was either Muddy Waters was there, B.B. was there, and Howlin' Wolf would be there the next week, and oh just — had some local guys that there was always music on the weekend.

MR: Was there any conflict between the church music and the religion and the secular blues that you were getting so fond of?

DG: Oh yeah, yeah. They were — there wasn't a strong conflict because — I'm going to tell this and then, you know in my neighborhood we had everything. When I say everything — on our street there was — three doors down there was people selling what we call hot clothes. You know, suits and everything, that people had shoplifted out of the stores and everything and, but deacons and, you know, all kinds of people would come there and they were religious people, you'd see them at church with that suit on and they got it from the hot table. Because it was almost a skill of survival. You know. But they weren't frowning too hard on the blues, unless you had a parent that was really — don't listen to this, this is the devil's music and all that. Well me, I didn't have it. I wasn't confronted with that you know. People used to party and do whatever they had to do but you'd see them up in church every Sunday nodding. And I was a unique kind of guy. When I say unique I was borderlining on being a gangster — no, not a gangster but being a criminal or whatever. I had a group of my friends, we had a crooked dice little game going. So we would gamble and the guy would throw out the crooked dice to me and I'd win money. You know a lot of money. Now this I thought — I'm pretty sure my mother didn't know about it and she probably didn't and maybe could have. But one day one of her friends in the same place where they used to have the music and Miss Ethel was her best friend, you know, my mother's friend. And Miss Ethel would come and get me and take me to the cafe and I would dance and do all kinds of stuff and she would give me maybe a little sip of beer or something. My mother didn't know about that. My mother was real strict, you know, a Christian person. But Miss Ethel would take me out and I could dance and she maybe'd give me a little sip of beer or stuff. So but Miss Ethel told my mother, "My name is James Richard," she said, "Ruby James Richard is down there. He'd be gambling with the guys." Now I was trying to be very slick and I probably thought I was real slick. I knew the time my mother would come because I had to keep my sisters, you know and everything, feed them and everything, wash the dishes and everything. So I would race home and be home and everything is clean and clear and everything, and be right there, and I always would make sure that I would be on time. So one day I was in my fifties. I was very up and [inaudible] and my mother was talking on the phone and I was listening

and she said, "You know the reason I left from under the hill, Ethel told me James Richard was down there with the guys gambling." And when we would gamble we would get a pint of corn whiskey that we knew where the guy who — we wouldn't do that, we'd get a pint of corn whiskey and but I never drank because I knew my mother could smell it on me and so, but she found me one day gambling. Well she must have came home early. And she never told me. She said, then I said, "When I saw James Richard down there gambling with the guys I knew it was time for me to move." She moved to a place called Georgetown. And in Georgetown it was — the high school was just built. It was — oh tennis courts, running where you could train, a running track and football and everything. The atmosphere was so changed from day to night. There was no guys gambling, there was no place to have corn whiskey hidden and everything. And I just adapted to that. I went out for football, I trained with the football team, I learned to play tennis and all kinds of stuff. But that was it. And my mother just got me out of that neighborhood into another neighborhood.

MR: Yeah, I'm glad because I might not be talking to you today if you had —

DG: Yeah. If I had stayed under the hill. My father was ready to be put in jail, because — but you know the thing with me, I realized two things with that gambling thing. There was a guy who lived across the street from me, he had a wife and two kids. And he would come, work all week and cash his check and then he would gamble and lose a portion of money and all and I couldn't — I stopped being in there. I said I can't do this because I'm taking money out of his wife's and two kids' money you know and I didn't have the heart to do it anymore and I stopped with the crooked dice thing because my heart wasn't cold enough to do that, to win the money off of him and then see that he didn't have that money to feed his kids and everything.

MR: I'd like to jump forward a little bit, and this is a bit of a tangent but in 1963 I think you were 23, that was the year that Medgar Evers was assassinated. And I'm wondering, can you put into words how that affected you?

DG: Well yeah. 1963 was the year that I graduated and got my bachelor's degree. But prior to that I would eat lunch with Medgar Evers for three years from '60 to '63. There was a place called Smacko's in Jackson on Nth Street. And Smacko's was the place right across the street from Medgar Evers' office, which was in the, we called it the State Office Building. And at lunchtime there were no fast food places, but people that didn't go home for lunch went to cafes and they had home cooked meals there. And as a college student I lived in the city which is on the east side of town, and the college was on the west side of town, so when I came to school over on the west side I wasn't going back home to eat lunch or anything because my mother was a domestic worker and she wasn't even there to cook a meal. So we ate at this place called Smacko's, it was every day for three years.

And that was, oh a very devastating part of my life, you know he was killed because my youngest sister was in a meeting that night that he had organized the youth to go and do a sit-in down in the city in Jackson. Because the reason for that is my youngest sister was a teenager and I was an adult. I was 23 years old. Had I sit-in they would have sent me to the State penitentiary and booked me as a real criminal or something like that. But as a youth, teenagers, my sister, they could arrest them but they couldn't keep them, not book them as any kind of crime or anything. So my sister, she did sit-in maybe one or two times. There would be so many students there they built a tent in the area down on the hill. They built a tent and they put all of them in the tent. And the parents would have to come and claim them, sign them out or come and get them. So my sister, she said — and I didn't know that — they would just throw bread, a loaf of a bread and bologna in the tent — treated them like they were animals. And I never knew that until very late in my life, how they treated my sister. Because my mother picked them up and my sister, she never talked about how they treated her. But Medgar Evers was a very, very good friend in that he would sit and tell me about all the different ventures that he had going into these towns where he was arrested. And this is something that never was written and probably won't be, but there was a guy named — I think his name was Robert Harriton. Mr. Harriton — he looked like white on sight. From two blocks away if you saw him coming you thought he was a white guy. And all his kids and his family. And we had a family like that. But Mr. Harriton and Medgar was very good friends. So when he got put in jail in a small town he would call Mr. Harriton. This was a real true story and hasn't been written — probably nobody knows about it. So Mr. Harriton would go down, Mr. Harriton on his driver's license had white, you know, on his driver's license. So he would go down and basically get Medgar out of jail. And they would go in and said Mr. Harriton this thing [inaudible] all right you've got my boy ba-ba-ba in jail, and they said, "oh well you know he's good," and they would get him out of jail and they would drive — probably have Medgar be driving him and he'd be sitting in the back from habit. And once they got out of the city limits they would just laugh and say wow, you know. And when Medgar got killed the reason I know this story is I have a friend, Willie Salor, his wife was the daughter of Mr. Harriton. And Mr. Harriton, his son played in my band in high school. His name was Robert Harriton. We called him Booty. And Booty was a baritone saxophone player. And the reason that music has been so good to me, in high school I had a band and we would play proms for white high school, junior high school and everything. We'd play for the proms. Because there was no canned music and everything, all music for the proms and graduation and everything was live music. 1950s, '57 and all of that — so we were playing this gig and Robert Harriton looked like a white guy. Nothing — hair, complexion and everything. So, and we were playing this junior

high school and obviously this girl thought he was a white guy playing in a black band. So she got up in front of him, and he played the baritone, he played [scats]. And she got in front of him and started dancing erotically and exotic — and Booty got so excited his nose started to bleed and he never stopped. He never stopped playing. He had a white shirt on, 'cause we all wear — and he just played and blood was running down on his shirt. And I always made a joke of him laughing, I said man, Booty, you probably would have had a heart attack if your nose didn't bleed. We had so much fun.

MR: I think that's a marvelous story and I love the fact that you can remember that he was playing [scats].

DG: Yes. In those days we didn't have a band you know. And — I mean bass. So he was the bari, he carried the bass. And it was "Blue" and we played it, and all the songs back in those days has "Rhythm" changes [scats]

[audio 35:35 — needs to be cut]

in at 36:20

So all of those songs had that "Rhythm" changes and you just name any little song back then that that worked.

MR: Yeah. And that 6/8 feel. That's what you get to get the people on the dance floor.

DG: Oh yeah.

MR: Wow. Wonderful. Let me move you up to summers in Chicago and if my sources are correct you're walking down the street and you hear what turned out to be Sun Ra?

DG: Yeah. That was interesting. So my whole career kind of started in 1959. In '58 I graduated from high school, my good mother — I would save my money. I was very good at saving. I majored in business in high school. I learned a lot about money. Thank God I've been able to apply — to stay on the right end of money you know. And so I had saved a hundred dollars, I remember very clearly. '58 was supposed to be the year that I would go to Chicago and when I went, if I had gone in '58 it would have been the first time that I've never seen the sign that says "colored" and "white" and "white water fountain" and everything. I would be able to go across the Mason-Dixon line. So my friend, God rest his soul, Paul Woods got put in jail for drinking. You know? He got arrested, he was inebriated. So my mother, being her good soul, "You've got to get Paul out." So my money that I had saved a whole year, I bailed Paul out and do you know two weeks later Paul was back in jail but anyway that's spoiled my whole summer. I was very, you know like frugal or whatever. I saved. I wouldn't spend money on anything that I didn't think was absolutely necessary. So anyway '59 I finally did the same thing, saved my money and went to Chicago. And I had an aunt who was very strict. She had a curfew. You know I'm 19 years old in Chicago, Chicago is a rough city, I'm down from Jackson, Mississippi. I wouldn't be able to survive in Chicago. But she didn't know that I

had been around a lot of the criminals and street people — I wouldn't say criminals, a lot of people that were on the funny side of the law and knew how to hustle and all that stuff. So I was very aware to a certain extent of what the street was like. But she said, "Okay you've got to be in after 7 o'clock or dark. So I was walking in the street in Chicago and I heard live music and you know I was definitely into music, I played in clubs and all that stuff. So I walked in and there was Sun Ra, there was Marshall Allen, Pat Patrick, John Gilmore, Ronnie Boykins and I'm not sure of the drummer, but so they were playing, they were rehearsing. I said ooh — and their music was very interesting and exciting 'cause you know I'd been listening to jazz on records but I hadn't heard anything like what Sun Ra was doing. So, and he — with his mild manner — and he said, "Hello, how are you doing?" and he'd nod. I said, "I play the trombone." He said, "Grab your horn and come to play with us tomorrow." And that's what I did. And I could read music. So Ronnie Boykins and I would do duets. He played the bass. And those musicians was well trained. I mean Marshall to the day is so good at sight reading, and he had played in Paris because he just turned 99 — he had played in Paris when Josephine Baker was over there — not that he played, but Marshall goes very deep. And he had just gotten out of the Army around that time. I think he got out — he joined the band in '58 and Julian Priester joined the band in '56 and Charles Davis, the late Charles Davis, he was around, he and Julian Priester got in the band around the same time. I'm not sure when James Spaulding was in the band but he's still with us. So ain't but a handful of people, I would say maybe four or five at the most, that go back as deep as Marshall and Julian Priester and myself played in the band.

MR: Were those fellows making any — hmm — were they making any money working with Sun Ra or was it more like this is just something I really need to do?

DG: Well they were making money. Let me see, now John Gilmore, he had a choice. Well he did, he played with Mingus, he played with Art Blakey. He recorded with Art Blakey. And he could have gone and been out there and played in the band but the music that Sun Ra was writing and creating was so challenging. That's what kept him into Sun Ra's music. He would mention, he said, Monk had some really hip and but he said he was more interested in what Sun Ra was doing harmonically in those intervals. And the reason, I don't know why but they kind of like decided that they loved music so all they wanted to do was play music and have a place to live and everything. And Sun Ra at the time I used to go — Sun Ra rehearsed every day all day. Every day all day. And I lived in New York and I was married and did — I was teaching and my son was just born and everything. But the guys who lived in the house with Sun Ra, and they pooled — I'm pretty sure they pooled their money, you know, for some basic stuff like Sun Ra would — would pay the rent. It was a joint effort and whatever gig they got, you know, they got

paid and then whatever portion of their rent, you know, went in. So I never truly understand it. But one thing I did know and I can say, Sun Ra never had a bank account so he dealt — most of his money was in cash — ten thousand — I remember going to Europe and Sun Ra would have these kind of dashiki things he had made these clothes, and he had a money belt. And I used to see that and I've seen his money belt. And he would have all of his money on him or somewhere, and then he always had members of the band around him and they were like his bodyguards. I figured that one out. I took it to the extent — and every time we went out someplace, you know, Sun Ra was never hardly alone because of I guess that. He always had the band around him and those guys were really really very quick in martial arts and everything. No weapons or anything but they could take care.

MR: Did you think of him as eccentric at the time?

DG: Yes. Because he was courageous. He was just like what I was saying about trying stuff. He would try stuff. Although I think he was probably one of the most adventurous or courageous guy out there in the music because he would try stuff. You know. He was always inventing something. And Rahsaan was like that you know. So I'll tell you what, there was two things that Sun Ra said to me and he would always make sure that he challenged me. But one night we were playing at Slug's and he knew that I could play changes because I was playing the whole week with Rahsaan at the Vanguard playing tunes fast and with changes and everything. And John Gilmore was my favorite of all because John could do it all. He could play all the fast stuff, he could play all the ballads, he knew all the lyrics and stuff, and he taught me a lot of songs, a lot of lyrics you know. And he could play changes. You know, "'Round Midnight" anything. "Giant Steps." So I'm saying that to say Sun Ra said to me one night at Slug's, he said, "Griffin, I know that you've been playing your licks and everything," he said, "but once you play it one time I don't want to hear you play the same lick twice tonight." And that was really opening up me. I had to really think of everything I played, the way I played it, and to make sure that I didn't play it the same way. And ever since then I used to challenge myself to do it that way. Then the other thing that Sun Ra said to me, we were in Milan, Italy in a theater for two weeks. And each night he would send one person out on the stand and they would play and then the band would come out and join them. That was the way he was doing it, the opening. So he said, "Griffin, I want you to go out tonight and the band won't come out until you get a standing ovation." I was out there, I don't know how long I played, but I was playing, playing, playing, playing, just me on the bandstand. Then I said, "Oh Lord what can I do" and I went into the multiphonics. And I held on to multiphonics and played them I don't know, magically or whatever came in, until that band, 'til the audience stood up and gave me a standing ovation. And then the band came

out. Now I was expecting Sun Ra to say — you know smile — he just looked at me as if hmpf, okay, so what. And sit down at the piano. And he was saying, "I knew you could do it but you didn't know you could do it." That was the lesson.

MR: That's wow. What a lesson.

DG: Yeah. I mean I was out there a half an hour until — "I don't care how long it took." The band would not come out until I got the standing ovation. And I got it.

MR: What did you learn subsequently from Rahsaan Roland Kirk? I understand that you helped him arrange some of his music and notate it. Is that correct?

DG: Yeah. Let me put it right like it is. Rahsaan was blind. He could write music out in Braille but he didn't know the system. So all the records on Atlantic, even starting when I was in college when I first met him, he recognized that I could hear pretty good. You know my pitch and everything. So he would sing a song — call me up at two or three and four in the night and sing a song and I would write it down. And he would trust me, the chords and everything. And I'd say okay how's this and you know how do you like this underneath that and everything I would do at those songs. And that was my thing with Rahs — and all those record dates, I wrote out the changes you know. I wrote the chord changes out and most of the time he played the melodies but there weren't — in the big band arrangements I had to write some melodies or some harmonies out. So I did all of his orchestrating or writing for all of the Atlantic records that he did.

MR: Was that Joel Dorn on board for those things?

DG: Yes. Joel Dorn produced most of those things from Atlantic. And yeah, we would do the recordings and I would go to Joel Dorn and he would ask me how much I want you know, for the arranging, for the writing. And I would give him a little small amount you know. I didn't know. I said, "Oh give me $75 or whatever." And then the next time I'd say maybe, "Give me $100" something like that. And I kept doing that. And one time I went to the union and I asked the union what's the union rate? And they told me okay well this price — I think they gave me the union rate. So I told Rahsaan the union rate and then he called me the next time and said, "Dick" you know "I paid" you know "the amount you charged me was Gil Fuller's. I pay him that much." I said, well I didn't know, they told me at the union. And he said, "Well that money comes out of my royalties" and everything. But anyway we had a little discussion about that but I didn't know because I was so under-rate — I wasn't charging enough. And then when I did charge the regular rate he called me up and we had a discussion about that. We had a little — like a child's — you know when children get to pouting and then they have a little argument and the next day they're playing you know, back on the scale playing. So we had those bouts. Another thing with Rahsaan I treated Rahsaan like he could see. And he liked that. He loved that. So we would go to [inaudible] I would tell him hey man,

have a look at that. And then we had this little inside thing. He had a way of rocking. And I said, "Rahsaan, don't go to that poor blind man move on me." And he would just laugh and say, "No, man, you pay me this amount of money" and everything. But he would say, "Dick, you know man, if I could see" and he started groaning. I said, "Uh uh, don't go there, poor blind man, don't pull that one on me, it ain't going to work with me today you know. And we would just have so much fun you know and laughing. He loved — because I wouldn't treat him like he was blind. He was smart. I'll tell you another thing about Rahsaan, he was probably the person that had the highest IQ of I've ever met. He could spell any word that you would – I would tell him to spell, he was very bright, very high IQ. And his friends were, one of his blind friends was a psychiatrist, and he was just smart. And then he never, if you met him one time he'd never didn't forget you or your name. And he always identified you by your record. He'd come in, I'd introduce him, "This is Dante." Yeah man, I heard you've got this record, you've got this record and this one and ba-ba. So he was a really smart guy collecting records and even the cassettes which were just kind of creeping in during the time I was with him.

MR: This morning I watched the now-classic or well known video of Rahsaan and the group on Ed Sullivan.

DG: Oh yeah.

MR: I think it was January 1971.

DG: That's right. '71.

MR: And there you are and I'm trying to think of a question here because it was quite an event. Do you remember how you felt afterwards?

DG: Oh yeah. Because I could see the whole thing going up to that and afterwards and the whole thing. Okay that was the result of the Jazz and People's Movement. We would go into these studios, Merv Griffin and all these different studios, The Tonight Show and everything, and just start playing New Orleans style music and interrupt their taping. So it went on and Mark — I forget the guy's name — was part of it and he's still around. But we would do this Jazz and People's Movement. So we were trying to get jazz to be played on network television. And it happened for a short minute. I remember playing The Today Show with Frank Foster and I did the Ed Sullivan Show with Rahsaan, and various shows started to have jazz performances. It lasted a hot minute, a hot minute. And at that time Jimmy Owens was on the David Frost Show I think it was with Billy Taylor was the music director and Thad Jones was in the pit band of CBS. And I was in Thad Jones's band at that time. All of that said, yes — so the show was — he had told Ed Sullivan, "We're going to play 'My Cherie Amour'" you know. And but when the show actually — it was a live show — when the camera came on to Rahsaan nobody knew exactly what he was going to do but we were thinking oh yeah, we didn't even rehearse,

we were going to play "My Cherie Amour" and we had done that. That's when he said "Kukumba" and then started with the whole thing. And everybody was just ready. And everything was on the spur of the moment and he introduced everybody later, Archie Shepp and Archie played, then Mingus, and the thing that Mingus and Rahsaan was doing was they played the dozens. And people don't understand that, that's when you're talking back and you're playing the dozens. Now I won't even go any deeper than that because most people from the era know what playing the dozens is and that's what they were doing on live television [scats]. And that was the language that we used and we played the dozens. And then he went into [scats] that's the "Haitian Fight Song," and we didn't know. And everything I tell everybody, all of those riffs were made on the spot.

MR: That was the question I had because I was watching you and at one point the camera was on the three of you in the horn section and I said, "I'll bet they're just like making that up and listening."

DG: Yeah. And that's one thing I did. See being with Rahsaan, a lot of the stuff he played was — I just played it because of my doo wop experience of playing with the full group, like "Say a Little Prayer" the first time everything came out just right because I was thinking like a doo wop group player [scats] that was made up right on the spot. [scats] And I would make up all those arrangements right on the spot out of my head [scats]. I could hear my part just like if I was singing in a vocal group and it was made up and nothing was personable and it was just like that's it you know. And the background was the same thing. That was made up right on the spot. We had never played that background, I just heard, you know, [scats] and McGhee, Charles McGhee — we were so tight because we had been playing with Rahsaan and he knew, he had perfect pitch as well and he could really match me real — so all of that was as crisp as you can get it, right on the spot.

MR: Well when you all walked off the stage, can you remember the conversation?

DG: Yes. Okay? Everybody was — like excited, oh wow. Roy Haynes, see that was my time to play with Roy Haynes you know. Roy Haynes to the day, it's like a really — everything he plays is different and innovative and fresh you know. And he mentioned somebody asked him about rudiments and everything and he said, "I don't do that because these hands are uneven" or something. He mentioned something like that. But oh, it was just — everybody was like wow — magic happened, and nothing was really rehearsed 'cause we thought we were going to be playing "My Cherie Amour" [scats]. And it was going to be just real kind of a soothing, organized performance, but it was wow. And everybody got to hear it.

MR: And Ed's comment afterwards, I forget his exact words but it just put a whole, I don't know it was quite humorous.

DG: Yeah. He was — he didn't know what to say he was just like whoa.

MR: What was that?

DG: And then where did that come from? And then we went into the Dixie — we called it the New Orleans style music, oh that was just it.

MR: Yeah. I was thinking how is he going to get out of this? How is Rahsaan going to wrap this up in short, he did.

DG: Yeah. That was the magic of him.

MR: There's a descriptive phrase that's sometimes over-used and that is "a force of nature" but I saw Rahsaan in a Rochester club, probably 1970, and that's how he struck me, as a force of nature — it was just incredible. And I think a lot of people in the audience, after one of his more — I won't say outlandish — but he was covered with instruments, right, and he's playing three things at once, and then he finished this song and there was this like small amount of applause. And he took the mic and he goes, "Thanks for that pitter patter."

DG: Yeah.

MR: We didn't know what to think, I think people were a bit in shock.

DG: Um hum. He was so smart, I was saying, and he would — if he was alive today I'm sure he would be talking about the politics and all the stuff that's going on. He would be addressing that and everything. But that's the smart part about him. He was very well — how can I say — like he would listen. He'd listen to so much and he could read Braille, and he would either read in Braille or listen to classical music. I'd go over to his house and that's the other side of it — I got a gift — to this day — a Christmas gift. I carry it in my trombone case that he gave me. And he would give gifts and have people over to his house for Christmas and everything. He was very personal and very, very influential and you know you never — those kind of people never really leave you in a sense, because I always — now just to the day somebody taught me on the trombone — I'm able to do it now, you know the circular breathing and stuff like that. And he did it way back in the '70s. He took my horn and he just played and played, circular breathing and everything. And he said, "Give it to me," and he said, "Dick, you can do it." And at that time I had no clue. I couldn't — it took me now these forty years to get to what he had taught me.

MR: Well we've got up to 1971.

DG: Okay. Yeah?

MR: I'm going to pause our recording here, and we'll be back. Hold on. Okay, hold on. Okay so we're back. I want to pose a question to you. I've had circumstances over the years where trying to get someone to hire the band or line up a gig, and someone's — you're on the phone and someone asks you, "Well what do you play? Describe your music." Have you ever had a circumstance either with your visual art or with your own music that

you would have to try to describe it yourself and what would you use as adjectives and terms to describe your creativity?

DG: Yes I've been asked that question and I basically say my music has no real category in the sense — I can play free music or avant garde music and I can play spirituals, I can play blues. I consider myself — if you thought of someone that was a linguistic, a linguist — I can speak seven or eight or nine languages. I can speak gospel, I can speak blues, I can speak rhythm & blues, I can speak rock, I can speak avant garde, I can speak straight ahead. You know. Any kind of category of music I fit. The problem that I have had is people tend to want to put me in one group and don't want me in another group. And I love all music. I mean I just recently now have been more active in the avant garde or the free music scene but I was always involved with it when I was with Sun Ra and Archie Shepp and Cecil Taylor. All these people, when I was playing with those people I played that style and I consider music sort of like a language you know. You can speak avant garde, I can speak that. I can speak French. I can speak Spanish. I can speak Italian. I can speak African dialect. I can speak [inaudible] all of these different languages, Africa — I got words and I know a few things in all of these languages. So music is the same thing you know. If you're really playing the blues, it's so deep. You can go in there and I can play a blues gig all night. I mean and I can play a gospel gig all night. I can sit down here at the piano, in fact I like

[plays piano, may need to edit 1:08:24]

I heard the voice of Jesus say, "Come unto me and rest." So all of these gospel songs of mine I love them and I play them and I hear them and I feel them you know. And I can play some of Cecil Taylor.

MR: I can see how

[more piano playing until 1:09:18]

MR: I asked Rashied Ali, I was trying to understand the motivation or the inspiration for playing what — I'll use your term, avant garde and I wondered if he, with his fellow musicians sat down and had a conversation about making the music more exploratory or adventurous. Did you talk about it? And he said no. We didn't ever talk about it. We just did it. But he went on to say that the music that they were doing was a reflection of the times. And he related some of the segregation things he had experienced, and he said, now I'm going to quote him, "We are not the same people that lived in the bebop era. We live in a different age and I think that's evolution. Everything changes over time and the music reflects the way you live."

DG: Yes. That's right. Okay. Good example: When I was in Indiana University in 1965 to 1967 I was always — well my friend Medgar Evers had been killed and President Kennedy had been killed, and I was in a recording session and my dear friend Dr. Martin

Luther King was killed. I was in a recording session. And Dr. King — and when I was in Jackson, I was eating lunch with Medgar Evers, Dr. King was eating lunch next door in a place called the College Inn, and he had a lot of celebrities like Harry Belafonte, Lena Horne, Sammy Davis Junior, James Baldwin, I saw all of those people in Jackson, when they came through Jackson. And I remember one time there was six of them all there in this place College Inn, and those people that I named, Harry Belafonte, you know, Lena Horne, and there was a lot, Sammy Davis Junior was there that time, and it was just a different time. Stokely Carmichael — we were the same age. I was there, he came through Jackson and SNCC, the group that he was involved — I used to play — I was playing at this place called Junior's Steak House. We had a Sunday afternoon jazz like gig there. And all the civil rights and freedom riders we called them, would come in and hear us play. And I remember one night after a gig, maybe we finished around twelve or something at night, I took six of the civil rights, you know, members home to my mother's house. She got up out of her bed, fixed us a full fledged breakfast with biscuits, you know, eggs, bacon, and my mother never complained about anything like that. And Sterling Janice Rose, I don't know if she's with us now but she came — she went to Howard University and you know that was the way my mother was. She was a giver. And she always told us it's better to give than to receive. And she was a domestic worker but she would go and our neighbor Miss Louise and Miss Bertha, they were getting old so she would go by and bathe them and feed them in the morning before she went to work and then after she came back from work she would come back and make sure and feed them and — but we called them home attendants now but she wasn't even expecting any money or anything, that's what she did. And we had to do that. And my cousin, the mother of this friend of mine, we called her Congetta, she had the underground railroad system going. Because she lived up near the railroad tracks and all the hobos that came through Jackson knew that they could stop at her house and get a meal. And she would feed them on the back porch but she wouldn't let them come inside the house. Congetta did that with no pay, you know what I'm saying? And by the knock on the door with her being, "Oh yeah come on in, sit down on the back porch." And the climate wasn't like it is now, it was always pretty warm or most of the time. It was just in February and January we may have had to wear coats and it got a little cool down there. It snowed every ten years. But Congetta would do that. That's the way it worked. Nobody went hungry. There was no homeless people per se, unless they decided they needed to be homeless. We took care of everybody. And everybody looked out for each other. Those who had mental or special needs or all those people, we took care of them too. Everybody knew, okay this person is not [inaudible].

MR: That kind of empathy and character it seems has stayed with you. Do you believe it's found its way into your composing and your visual artwork?

DG: Oh sure, yeah. More and more now, like I say the older I get the more I really refer back to what my mother taught me and how it's better to give and it's kind of unpopular to be counting now, because people take advantage of that, you know take kindness as a weakness. They were — you know if you give them something people think they're getting over on you, they're thinking oh everybody — not everybody but a lot of people are hustling and trying to take as much as — there's three types of people — this one of my friends named Johnny Grimes, he told me there's three types of people in the world. There's givers, there's takers, and there's users. The users and takers fall in the same group a lot. But the givers are just unique. And what you give is what you get. If you give love and compassion and understanding you get it. It might not come in the form that you want to but you get it you know. But if you give a lot of hustling and untruthful and getting over people, you'll get it. It'll come back at you. That's the law of nature.

MR: Do you do anything on purpose to inspire yourself for new compositions or new visual arts? If you're staring at a blank canvas what compels you to start?

DG: Well the latest series I've been doing is called Peace, Hope and Love for the Human Race. But I'm only using three colors, black, white, and red. And with that combination right there I try to blend those three colors in some kind of art form that shapes and that looks good to me you know. Yeah. So that's my latest thing. But this piece behind me is "'Round Mid-/Bright Mississippi." And all of that can be seen on my website, it's DickGriffin1.com. And — my music and my art. And this last gig I played in Savannah I started to give my CDs away because very few people now have CD players and everything. So I did support that and it was very interesting what happened. "I'm overstocked with CDs and I don't think I'll ever be able to get rid of all of them in this day and time because they're fading out, so I want anybody who wants a CD to come up and get it for no charge." And I say, "When I do sell them it's for 20 bucks." And do you know the majority of the people came up and gave 20 bucks, I even sometimes as much, and it was just a handful of people I gave them for free.

MR: Thus proving your givers' category.

DG: Yeah.

MR: Yeah.

DG: Yeah because a lot of people they don't have the money. They want the CD but they don't have the money. And it was so interesting, a guy came up and he had a friend upstairs, and he said, "My friend wondered if you took credit cards." I said, "Yeah, I can do that, I have a Venmo account but if the lady wants it just come down and I'll give it to

her." I mean you know if she didn't have that I'd take a check or whatever, just give it to her.

MR: Yeah. All right. I'm going to try something out on you and you'll have to forgive my vocals.

DG: Okay.

MR: But I want to see if — this is a Dick Griffin song from — if I don't deliver it very well I'll give you a hint that I believe it's about 40 years old. Okay, here we go: [scats].

DG: "Peaceful Thinking."

MR: Say that again?

DG: "Peaceful Thinking" that's on my first record.

[plays piano]

MR: I'm not really hearing the keyboard over Zoom. So was there an inspiration for that?

DG: Yeah. It might be "Jakuba's Dance"

MR: "Jakuba's Dance."

DG: Yeah that's my son. And when he was a small kid, like two years old, he would be trying to dance and he would be jumping around and bouncing around and I called it "Jakuba's Dance."

MR: Yes. It's lovely. And I noticed when I was trying to practice just doing the melody, it sounds almost like pentatonic, a little bit without the accompaniment. It sounds like a sound from an Asian country.

DG: Yeah. It is.

[plays piano]

MR: Were you pleased that your son pursued the music business?

DG: Yes. Believe it or not it was a weird kind of situation with my son. His mother passed two years ago and my former wife, I never married, we got a divorce kind of early in my son's life but I never re-married. But he was always into music. Okay I'll give you an example about him. At two years old he could play the piano and he would go [scats] "Popcorn" he had a song. He wrote all these songs. "Peanuts" and everything [scats] "Popcorn" [scats] so he was composing way back then, and then when I was playing the trombone he would come in and he could play the trombone. He could hold it up and play it but he could only get to fourth position. So I figured out okay he probably needs to play the trumpet because then at least he won't have to have the arm reach thing. And then that was when we were living in Manhattan at 70 West 95th Street. Then we moved to Teaneck when he went to the first grade. So he stayed in music up until junior high he was getting ready to go to junior high school and I got a divorce, me and his mother divorced. But I stayed in Teaneck so I could be a part of his life and everything, and oh he was winning band contests during those times, the state band and everything. And in

the summer I had the honor of, this was a friend of Ed Pasant. He's not with us anymore. His daughter played the clarinet and Ed played the clarinet, and they would have a summer band with the parents and I would play trombone and my son would be playing the percussion and everything, and that was really, really nice. So my son, he never had like a day job, you know like kids wanted to work, you know at 7-Eleven or all these different stores, my son was the only child, so he got a job at 7-Eleven, and he was there for a couple of weeks. He didn't know how to hold the broom to sweep, because he had never done it. He never had to do it. He was an only child you know, and his mother did everything for him, so he didn't know how to sweep the floor or how to clean up and do everything. I would go watch. And I'd park my car like in a second where I could just watch him. And I would just be laughing, I'd say that boy, I've got to show him how to hold a broom and how to sweep and everything. That job lasted about two weeks and that was the only job I think I ever remember him having other than playing music.

MR: Yes and we've had the pleasure of his talents here at Hamilton College a number of times.

DG: Oh yeah. Yeah. He comes up, he used to come up annually and would play with Doctor Woods. But yeah, so now he's 53 years old, he's never had a job doing anything but playing music. And he got to be pretty good — well he is pretty good I've got to say. He reads very well. He plays all styles, like I do. He just subbed in a Broadway show at the Wintergarden Theater, a really really big show there and he did pretty good there. And he said coming up March 1 he's going to be doing "Dream Girls," it's going to be a three week run, which is like a Broadway — one of the big shows of Broadway. So I'm proud of him and he's doing well and never done anything but music.

MR: That is really something in this day and age.

DG: Yeah.

MR: This has been a most marvelous conversation. I want to wrap up with, this is sometimes a hard question. If you go to bed at night and you reflect on your career, is there a gig or a road trip or an association that comes to your mind as the pinnacle of what you've done?

DG: Several, several, several in a sense.

MR: I'll give you several, that's fine.

DG: Okay. Well my stint with Abdullah Ibrahim, I played with him five years, enjoyed his music, learned a lot from him. That was the longest stint I've ever been with any particular band or situation. Then the best band leader that I work with and I always say stands out in my mind, Marvin Gaye, because of what he did after the gig. He would come down after all of the accolades and women being you know flirtatious and throwing their underwear on the bandstand. He would come down every night, look me in my eyes, shake my hand and say, "Man I really thank you for performing with me." And my dear

friend, like what we consider myself as a brother — because I never had a brother — Freddy Waite, we were in the first grade together and throughout college and everything it was a very strong influence. He was responsible for me getting in the band and doing a lot of things. But Marvin and I we used to talk about Freddy, how Freddy helped him play, you know taught him drums. Because Marvin could play the piano, he'd play the drums, he'd play several other instruments. So that one of the highlights of my life. Sun Ra was a highlight. As a teacher, performer Rahsaan Roland Kirk I liked. And Charles Mingus, my influence that I had for playing in his band. And believe it or not James Brown, some of those people that I played with at the Apollo Theater, 'cause I played the house band at the Apollo Theater. Dionne Warwick, James Brown, Marvin Gaye. I actually played with Michael Jackson and Janet Jackson. I played with the Jacksons for a week at Radio City Hall so I got a chance to perform on the bandstand with those people, Michael Jackson and Janet Jackson.

MR: They would have horn parts for — someone would write the arrangements and you'd come in and be expected to read them, correct?

DG: Oh yeah. That was in the Apollo Theater every week different people would come in. And that way when I played with Gladys Knight and the Pips and there was an arranger called Maurice King. Maurice King influenced Thad Jones and some of the writers out of Detroit. But his arrangements were off the hook to the day, he was a very great arranger. Maurice King.

MR: I bet he got more than $75.

DG: Oh yes. Let me tell you this one, this is a real good one and it's an honest one. Okay Pee Wee Ellis and I were very good. I was ghost writing for Pee Wee Ellis. So when Pee Wee Ellis would get an arrangement assignment, he lived on Longfellow Avenue in the Bronx. He would call me up. And I didn't sleep a lot at night. I mean whatever. I slept — I could go two hours sleep for days or nights. So Pee would call me up and it'd be like late at night, so I would go up and he would have these arrangements. "Body Talk" [inaudible] Esther Phillips, and most of those CTI arrangements that you see that Pee Wee Ellis did I was a ghost writer. So we would come up, "Hey Dick, we've got to have this ready for tomorrow" and blah. And then he said — he played me the track and he said, "What you hear here?" And I'd start humming. He said, "Write it down." I would write out the riff and everything. So and then when the recording was done and then the copies and all were made, Pee Wee and I would go down to CTI records and Creed Taylor would call me in and give me a check but no credit on the record or anything of me being on it, see that was the ghost writing. And then he'd call Pee Wee in and pay Pee Wee. And I did that a lot for my ghost writing with Pee Wee.

MR: That is a behind-the-scenes story for sure.

DG: Oh yeah. No one would know who was the ghost writer on a lot of these arrangements. They might have a big name out there, you know this is this person, this is this arranger. But the ghost writing that goes underneath would be much different.

MR: Yes. I remember Bucky Pizzarelli talking about the chart on Ray Charles' arrangement of "Georgia" and he said, "You know we're still not sure who actually wrote it." It's got someone's name but he could have farmed it out, it could have been farmed twice or — that's the music business I guess.

DG: I'll tell you something too that a lot of people don't know and wouldn't know unless I told them, you know Hank Crawford, Hank Crawford had a style of making an eight piece group sound like a big band. He got that, he learned that from my teacher whose name is Mr. William W. Davis. We called him Prof. Davis. He came to Jackson State and he started with Prof. and Hank Crawford and I used to talk about that. Prof Davis was probably one of the best arrangers that I knew. He wrote for the marching band. And we had this arrangement on "I'll Be Seeing You" you know. And he had a very nice [scats]. Big band [scats]. [Sings] And I'll be seeing you [scats]. So we'd be marching off the bandstand. But I wrote an arrangement on "Summertime" for the marching band way back in ' 63.[scats] So you know I gave it to Pee Wee. And we would open it with James Brown playing it for a whole week. Every time he came through the Apollo Theater, James loved jazz and he would open up with that arrangement. So we'd do [scats] and James would come out doing his thing [scats]. So we did it for the whole week and then at the end of the week, all right, James sent somebody down and said, "James wants to buy the arrangement, man. How much you want for it?" And I told him, "Union scale." And he said, the guy came down and said that was too much. I wanted James to have the arrangement. I would have given it to him. See I didn't know that was a big mistake. He said that was too much and that was the last I heard of it you know. And it would have been an honor for him because he just loved it and he would have been playing it all throughout his tour and everything. But I charged him too much and he said that was too much so, and the next thing they're on the bus and they're gone. But it was funny. I learned my lesson then.

MR: All right.

DG: Maybe, maybe one other time I might have done that and overpriced myself out of a gig. But I found out the best way is to say, "Okay how much are you willing to give me for it." And then be like that.

MR: Well I appreciate all this knowledge and stories you've told me and it's been a highlight for me.

DG: Oh thank you so much. It's, you know, the thing, out of the whole thing is the truth. See everything that I told you is straight up, the straight up truth you know. And you know I

didn't butter it up. I just had to tell you the truth. And that's what's so strong now. They said there's a saying that the truth will set you free you know, and it will. And it's just — if you tell the truth you don't have to have a good memory.

MR: Well said. Thanks for your time. Congratulations on your career.

DG: All right. So thank you so much. I've enjoyed sharing and it's been a pleasure. Thank you so much.